

Leading Beyond *Boundaries*



ADAPTIVE & TECHNICAL CHALLENGES

Adaptive challenges can only be addressed through changes in people's priorities, beliefs, habits, and loyalties. Making progress requires going beyond any authoritative expertise to mobilise discovery, shedding certain entrenched ways, tolerating losses, and generating the new capacity to thrive anew.

-Ronald Heifetz, Harvard professor, Leadership expert

Technical	Adaptive
Technical challenges are well defined and clear	Adaptive challenges are tangled, complex problems composed of multiple systems
They are familiar problem/ issues	They are unique issues
Known solution: can be solved with knowledge and procedures already in hand	Unknown solution: cannot be resolved by expert knowledge and routine management alone
Involves knowledge, expertise and procedures – SOP	Requires new/continuous learning, innovation, and new patterns of behavior
Technical challenges follow tried and tested success stories	Adaptive challenges follow changing attitudes, values, and deep-seated behaviors
These challenges command people to solve the issue	These challenges mobilize people to solve the issue

ADAPTIVE & TECHNICAL CHALLENGES

21st century leadership has adaptive challenges

Technical Manager	AND	Adaptive Leader
• Cost control • Best-practices systems and processes • Disciplined • Intellectually intelligent • Technical manager		• Innovation • Vision and values driven; creative • Flexible, responsive • Emotionally intelligent • People manager

ADAPTIVE & TECHNICAL CHALLENGES

- **Dance:** engaged into day-to-day activities
- **Balcony:** higher view that allows us to awaken to our highest wisdom, potentials and vision.

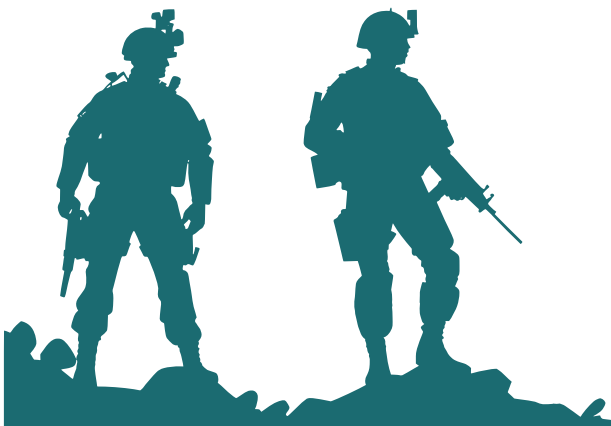


MINDSETS

FROM

LOYAL SOLDIER

- Respond to expectations
- Comply and appease
- Communicate at task levels
- Wait to be invited



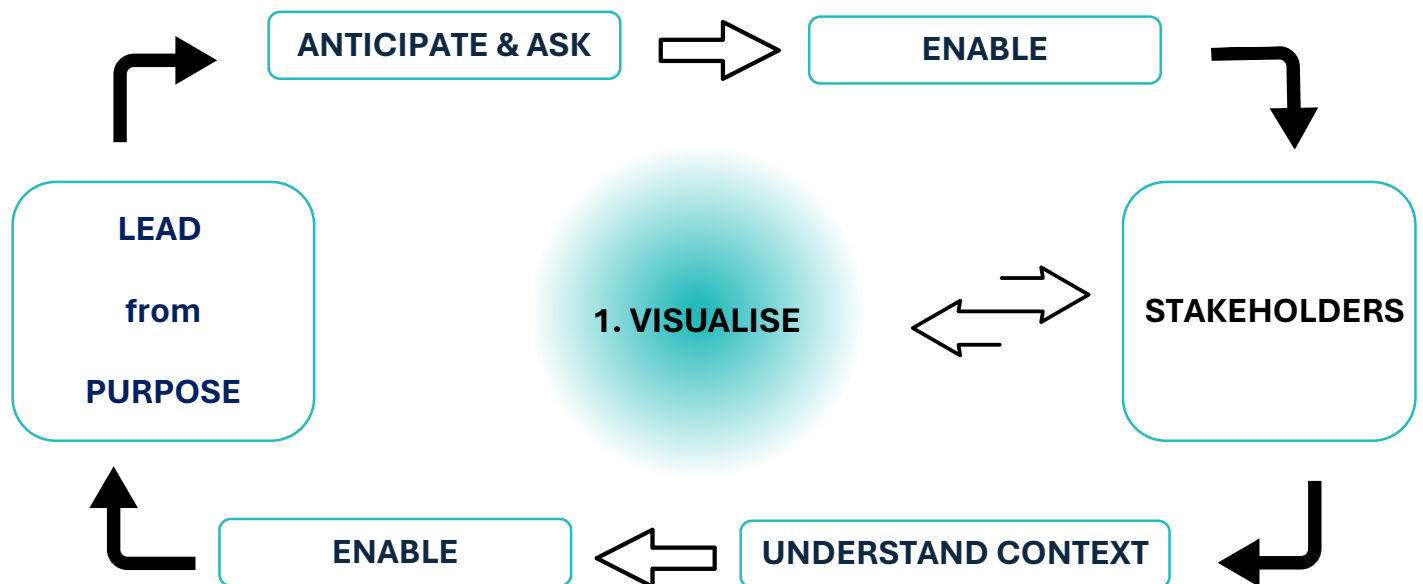
TO

GROWTH PARTNER

- Anticipate & engage
- Create & collaborate
- Communicate impact
- Influence by design



VALUE FRAMEWORK



- **V – Visualise:** Think of the big picture. Look at the impact. See the long term benefit. How will your actions today lead to long term value creation? Imagine different stakeholders being joyful.



- **A – Anticipate and Ask:** Notice the emergent patterns and anticipate the path forward. Read the field and the room and analyse for the hot spots. Ask for what will transform the situation and focus on learning as much about the context.



- **L – Lead from Purpose:** Position yourself in a way that allows you to activate purpose. Purpose allows you to have a seat at the table and operate from a position of knowledge and cause.



- **U – Understand Context and Cultural Nuances:** Adapt and design communication basis cultural priorities. Work to build Trust and impact.



- **E – Enable, Energise and Engage:** Value creation occurs through enablement of stakeholders and design for impact for their priorities.

VALUE FRAMEWORK

VISUALISATION

- **If this succeeds beyond expectations, what is different 3–5 years from now?**
- **Who benefits first, who benefits most, and who benefits last?**
- **What value is created that does not show up on a dashboard?**
- **What has become easier, safer, faster, fairer, cheaper, more accessible...?**
- **What would future leaders thank us for starting today?**

VALUE FRAMEWORK

ANTICIPATE & ASK

- What patterns are repeating that we might be normalising?
- What questions are we afraid to ask? Why?
- Where is energy increasing, and where is it draining?
- What feels unspoken but influential in this situation?
- What question, if asked now, could meaningfully shift the trajectory?

VALUE FRAMEWORK

LEAD FROM PURPOSE

- What is the cause I am serving beyond my role or title?
- What about this future success would excite me personally?
- Where am I reacting from position instead of acting from purpose?
- If I spoke from purpose, what would I say differently?
- What is the “compound interest” of the actions you are taking today?

VALUE FRAMEWORK

UNDERSTAND CONTEXT & CULTURAL NUANCE

- **Am I speaking the language of my stakeholder? Or expecting them to learn mine?**
- **What does “success” mean in this culture, not in theory?**
- **What behaviours are rewarded here — even if unofficially?**
- **What would be respectful here that might look ineffective elsewhere?**
- **Where might my intent be correct but my impact misaligned?**

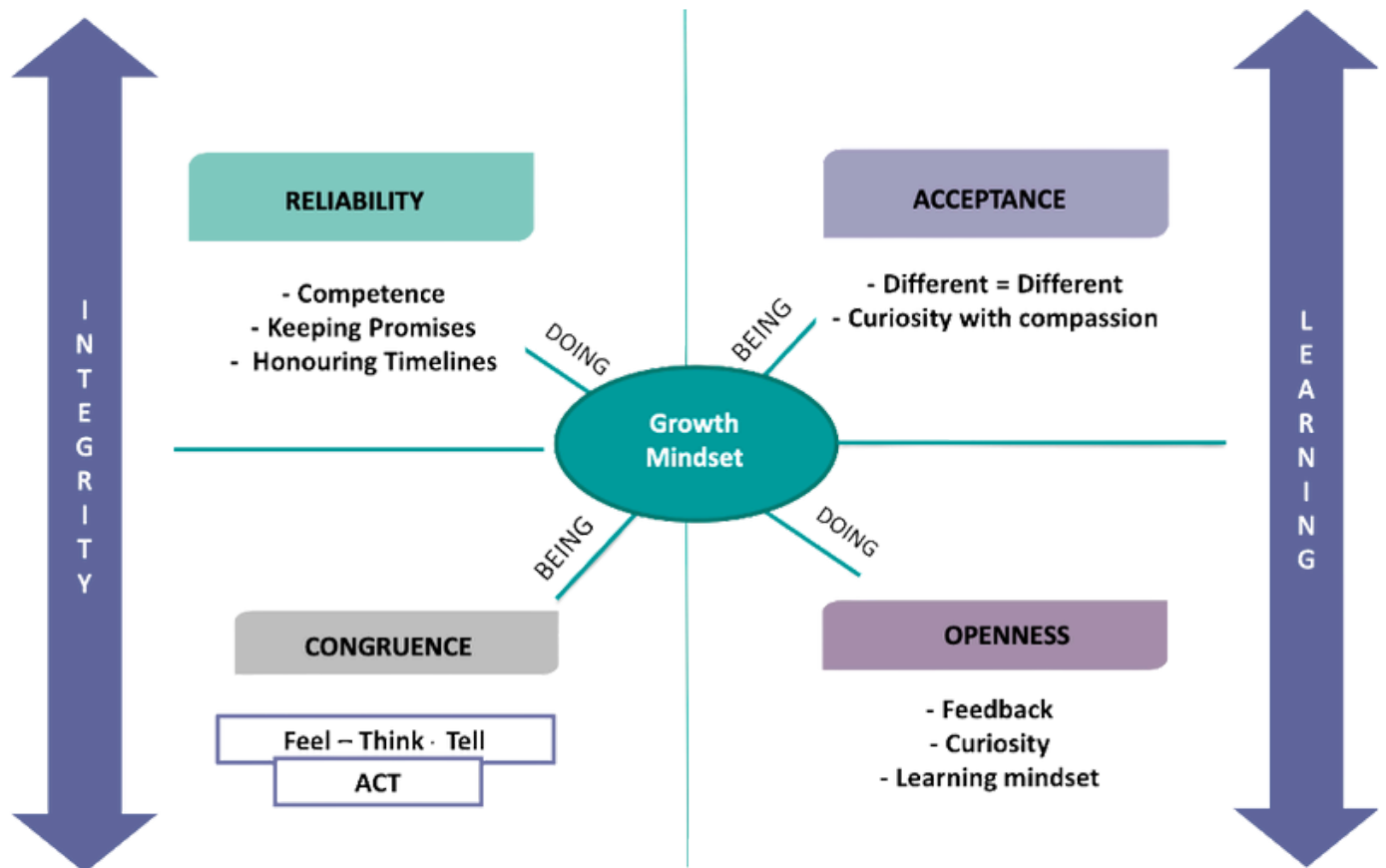
VALUE FRAMEWORK

ENABLE, ENERGIZE & ENGAGE

- What is currently making it hard for others (stakeholders/ end-users) to do their best work?
- Where is the friction? How can we resolve it best?
- What needs to be removed, not added?
- Apart from delivering what is needed, how can we deliver delight?

NOTES

TRUST MODEL



ELEMENTS OF TRUST

Reliability

- Take action
- Keep promises
- Competent
- Meet deadlines
- Be on time
- Follow up – follow through
- Deliver

Acceptance

- Respect another's point of view
- Be empathetic
- Be non-judgmental about a person
- Listen
- Allow mistakes
- Accept limitations
- Don't try to change people

Openness

- Obligation to dissent
- Clarify expectations
- Be willing to hear what others say
- Be honest about limitations
- Be straightforward – data driven
- Tell people how you feel, what you think, and believe
- No hidden agendas - fairness

Congruence

- Talk straight
- Don't play games
- Be sincere
- Set boundaries
- Make rules clear
- Walk my talk – Head - heart – hands - words
- Don't be too kind
- Integrity
- Alignment

TRUST- RELIABILITY

The first element of trust is reliability. People you relate to want to know if you do what you say you will do. It is pretty hard to have confidence in a person who makes promises they don't keep. Competence is an given.

Don't make promises you can't keep, even if you think it will smooth over the situation temporarily, or appease in an angry situation. In the long run it will hurt you. Do what you say you will do, and if you can't or won't do it, don't say you will. That's the first element of trust—reliability.

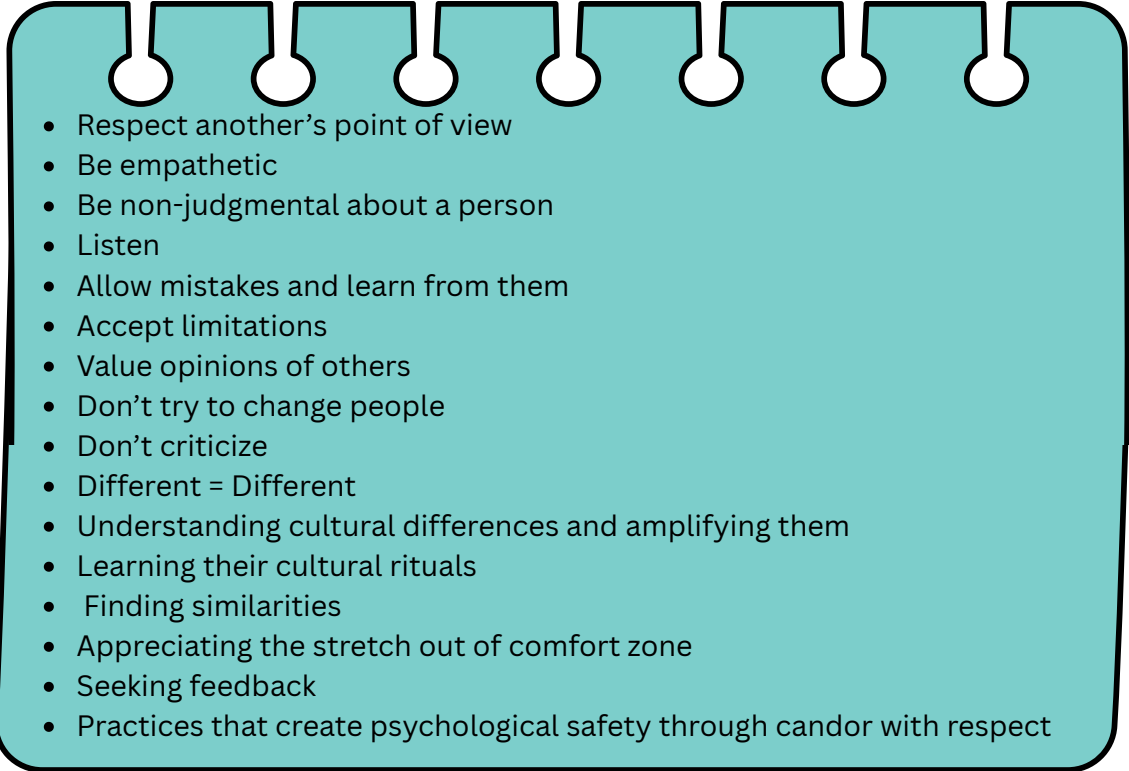
- 
- Take action
 - Keep promises
 - Meet deadlines, Punctuality
 - Competent
 - Follow up—follow through
 - Deliver
 - Backing promises with testimonials and evidence
 - Recovering from breakdowns effectively
 - Demonstrated competence
 - Reputation and price point

TRUST- ACCEPTANCE

As necessary as reliability is, it alone will not build trust in an interpersonal relationship. There are more elements involved. The second is acceptance.

All people want to be accepted for who they are. Not judged, criticised or made to feel inferior. It is easy to give the impression to others that they are slightly stupid or inadequate for not understanding as much about the company, department, or project as the person involved understands. Or, the other person may feel 'put down' by the use of technical jargon, obscure references, or guilt accusations that they are not aware of or familiar with.

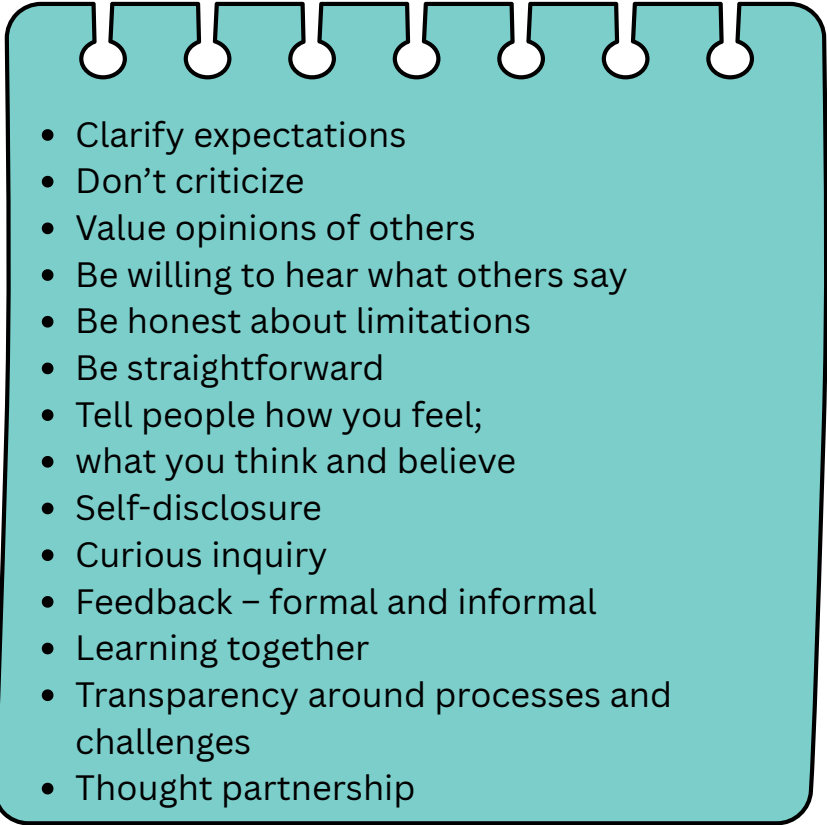
Accept the other person for who they are—young or old, the most intelligent or the hardest-working, the not-so-intelligent, tall or short, good looking or ugly. The other person, as long as he or she is relating to you, is OK and it is up to you to let that person know that when you are with him or her, that person is the most important person in the world. You are not judging or criticising them—you are accepting other people as they are and for what they are.

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- Respect another's point of view
 - Be empathetic
 - Be non-judgmental about a person
 - Listen
 - Allow mistakes and learn from them
 - Accept limitations
 - Value opinions of others
 - Don't try to change people
 - Don't criticize
 - Different = Different
 - Understanding cultural differences and amplifying them
 - Learning their cultural rituals
 - Finding similarities
 - Appreciating the stretch out of comfort zone
 - Seeking feedback
 - Practices that create psychological safety through candor with respect

TRUST- OPENNESS

The third element of trust is openness. People tend to want to cooperate best with people who will 'level' with them, not hide anything, and give them the whole story (even though some of the details may be a bit unpleasant).

'People can take good news or bad news, but they can't take surprises.' If you discover there has been a change of plans that affects another person, or you are displeased with work results or family experiences, your related person should be the first to know. The other person will respect and trust you more for your openness. You will be the kind of person that is known as honest and straightforward, and (if acceptable is included in openness) people will want to relate with you. Besides, if you openly tell the people you relate with about how you feel, what you think and believe and what you consider priorities, you will be more believable. People relate better with people they trust.

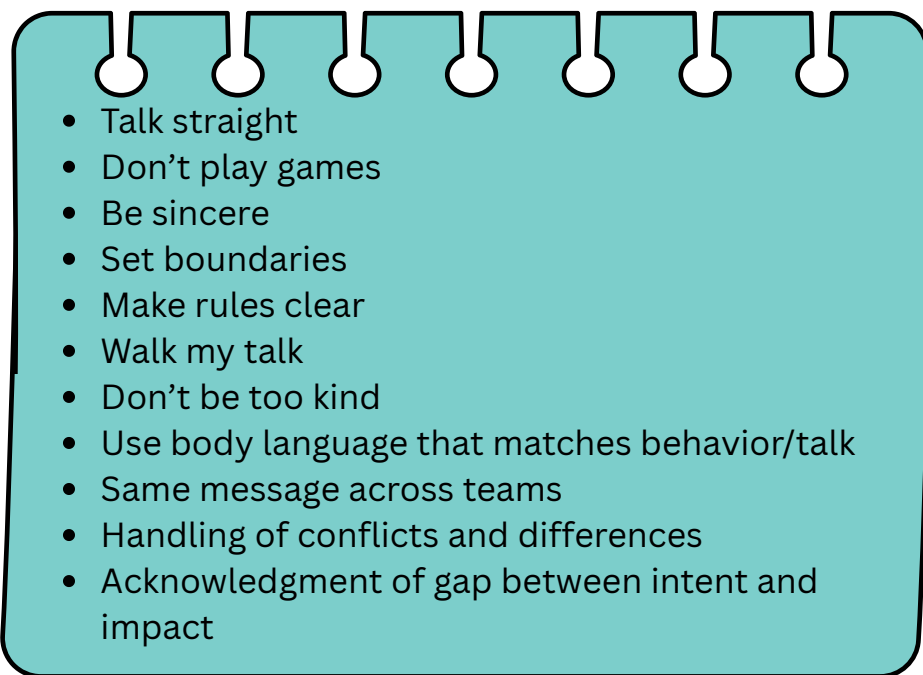
- 
- Clarify expectations
 - Don't criticize
 - Value opinions of others
 - Be willing to hear what others say
 - Be honest about limitations
 - Be straightforward
 - Tell people how you feel;
 - what you think and believe
 - Self-disclosure
 - Curious inquiry
 - Feedback – formal and informal
 - Learning together
 - Transparency around processes and challenges
 - Thought partnership

TRUST- CONGRUENCE

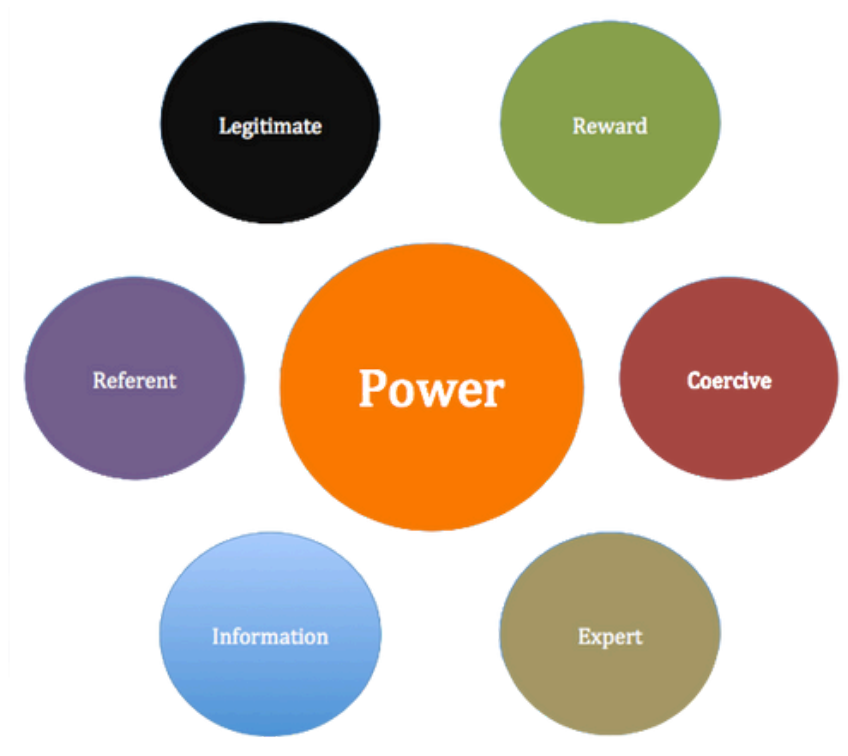
The fourth and final element that builds trust is congruence—the knowledge that what you say is on track with what you believe, what you know to be true, and what you do.

Congruence sounds the same as reliability, but there is a difference. Reliability means following up and seeing through the promises and commitments you make. It means 'I'll do what I say I'll do'. Congruence means saying and doing what you believe in the moment, being straightforward and honest, saying what is true, even if it is unpleasant and not exactly what you think the other person wants to hear.

No person will remain long in any relationship if he or she is deceitful, and that's not what is meant here.

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- Talk straight
 - Don't play games
 - Be sincere
 - Set boundaries
 - Make rules clear
 - Walk my talk
 - Don't be too kind
 - Use body language that matches behavior/talk
 - Same message across teams
 - Handling of conflicts and differences
 - Acknowledgment of gap between intent and impact

TRUSTED ADVISOR



$$\text{Trusted Advisor} = \text{Energy} * \text{Rank} * \text{Trust}$$

Legitimate - This comes from the belief that a person has the formal right to make demands, and to expect others to be compliant and obedient.

Reward- This results from one person's ability to compensate another for compliance.

Expert – This is based on a person's high levels of skill and knowledge

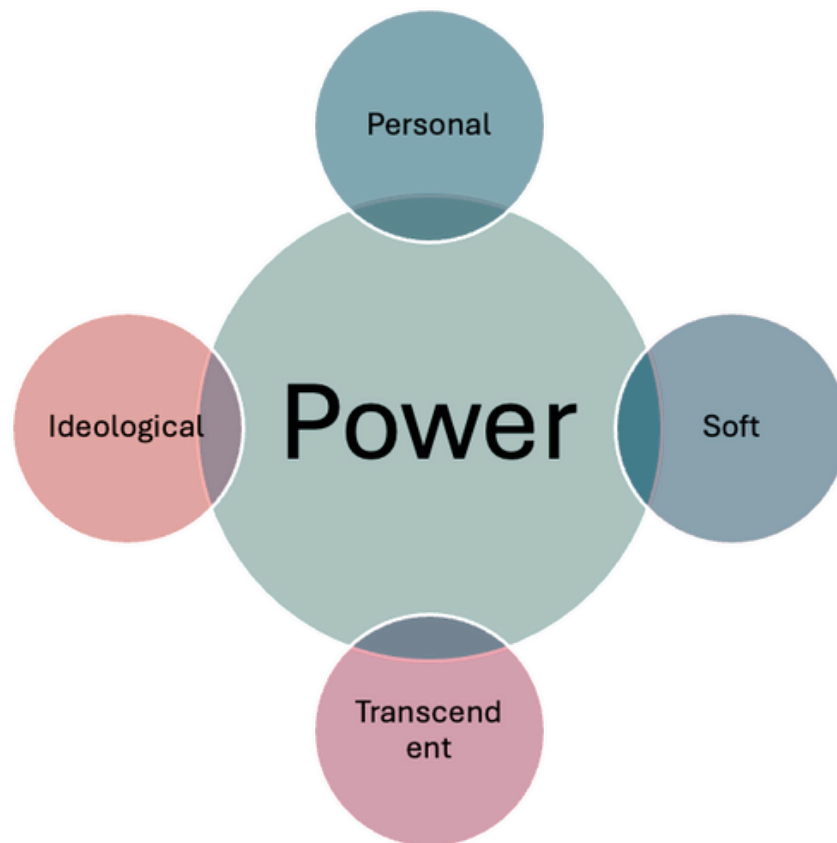
Referent – This is the result of a person's perceived attractiveness, worthiness and right to others' respect.

Coercive – This comes from the belief that a person can punish others for noncompliance.

Informational – This results from a person's ability to control the information that others need to accomplish something.

EXTRINSIC POWER SOURCES

TRUSTED ADVISOR



Personal Power – Manifestation of an individuals’ energy, vision, ability to communicate, capacity to influence and emotional intelligence.

Ideological Power- Comes from an ideal or a vision.

Soft Power – You hold a certain influence which others are weary of disrupting as it would impact their wellbeing (which is connected to your wellbeing).

Transcendent power- Connection to something larger than ourselves to the creator or spirit, the natural world or wellbeing of the planet.

INTRINSIC POWER SOURCES

Value equality and power levelling rituals Status is connected to merit and ability. ⇐

Power Distance (PDI)

⇒ Value Hierarchy and role stature. Status is connected to rank & authority

Individual needs over collective needs. ⇐

Individualism v/s Collectivism (IDV)

⇒ Collective needs over individual needs.

Heroic focus on accomplishment. ⇐

Masculinity v/s Femininity (MAS)

⇒ Cooperative focus on accomplishment.

Clarity focus. Avoidance of unfamiliar. ⇐

Uncertainty Avoidance Index (UAI)

⇒ Embracing the unfamiliar. Shaping reality.

Focus on visible outcome. Instant culture. ⇐

Short term v/s Long term orientation (LTO)

⇒ Faith in invisible manifestation. Continuity focus.

Immediate gratification. Pleasure and materialism are integral to living. ⇐

Indulgence v/s Restraint (IND)

⇒ Delayed gratification. Pleasure and material are distractions to living.

GEERT HOFSTEDE' CULTURAL DIMENSIONS

Power Distance: Power Distance is the extent to which the less powerful members of organizations and institutions (like the family) accept and expect that power is distributed unequally. This dimension is thought to date from the advent of agriculture, and with it, of large-scale societies. Until that time, a person would know their group members and leaders personally. This is not possible where tens of thousands and more have to coordinate their lives. Without acceptance of leadership by powerful entities, none of today's societies could run.

Individualism vs. Collectivism: Individualism is the extent to which people feel independent, as opposed to being interdependent as members of larger wholes. Individualism does not mean egoism. It means that individual choices and decisions are expected. Collectivism does not mean closeness. It means that one "knows one's place" in life, which is determined socially. With a metaphor from physics, people in an individualistic society are more like atoms flying around in a gas while those in collectivist societies are more like atoms fixed in a crystal.

Masculinity vs. Femininity: Masculinity is the extent to which the use of force is endorsed socially. In a masculine society, men are supposed to be tough. Men are supposed to be from Mars, women from Venus. Winning is important for both genders. Quantity is important and big is beautiful. In a feminine society, the genders are emotionally closer. Competing is not so openly endorsed, and there is sympathy for the underdog. This is NOT about individuals, but about expected emotional gender roles. Masculine societies are much more openly gendered than feminine societies.

GEERT HOFSTEDE' CULTURAL DIMENSIONS

Uncertainty Avoidance Index: Uncertainty avoidance deals with a society's tolerance for uncertainty and ambiguity. Uncertainty avoidance has nothing to do with risk avoidance, nor with following rules. It has to do with anxiety and distrust in the face of the unknown, and conversely, with a wish to have fixed habits and rituals, and to know the truth.

Short Term vs. Long Term Orientation: In a short-time-oriented culture, the world is essentially as it was created, so that the past provides a moral compass, and adhering to it is morally good. Long-term orientation deals with change. In a long-time-oriented culture, the basic notion about the world is that it is in flux, and preparing for the future is always needed. This dimension predicts life philosophies, religiosity, and educational achievement.

Indulgence vs. Restraint: Indulgence is about the good things in life. In an indulgent culture it is good to be free. Doing what your impulses want you to do, is good. Friends are important and life makes sense. In a restrained culture, the feeling is that life is hard, and duty, not freedom, is the normal state of being.

WORKSHEET

- How would you choose to prioritise?
- How would you communicate? What will gain attention and credibility?
- What is the definition of success for your stakeholders? How do we measure the same?

NOTES

CASE 1

- A key stakeholder has asked for a new addition to an existing app.
- Basis your initial research, you believe this might be a challenge to solve technically.
- There is an urgent business need for the same.
- How will you and your team approach this situation?

CASE 2

- A particular development piece involves getting perspectives of various stakeholders. Some of these stakeholders do not engage directly and may not have time and patience to offer feedback.
- How will you approach the situation?

CASE 3

- A recent project that you are working on was running well till about two weeks back. However, the deadlines are being missed and the team feels overwhelmed. There is an error as well as a certain improvement that is going to take longer than anticipated.
- Your seniors have given their word to the stakeholders that the project will be delivered ahead of schedule.
- How will you approach this situation?

NOTES

STAKEHOLDER MAP

Category

Initials



People in my team

...



People higher up in the hierarchy I need to work with or influence

...



Peers and others I need to interact and work with

...



People who can help me develop and grow

...



Others: In my community, industry contacts, etc..

...

STAKEHOLDER MAP

STEP 1: Place your People

Choose where to put the various people you just identified – perhaps using the categories or choosing another way to use your page. Draw triangles around each initial to make them different to you. **Put the triangle closer to “ME” if you know the individual well or if you interact frequently.**

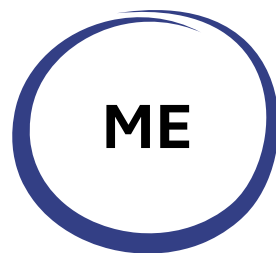
STEP 2: Characterize your relationships

Trust: Use a line to represent the degree to which you feel you can count on the person and be fully open and vulnerable. **Make the line thicker to show trust.**

Reciprocity: Add arrows to represent the degree to which you initiate and give OR you benefit/receive in this relationship. **Make the line two-way if reciprocity is equal.**

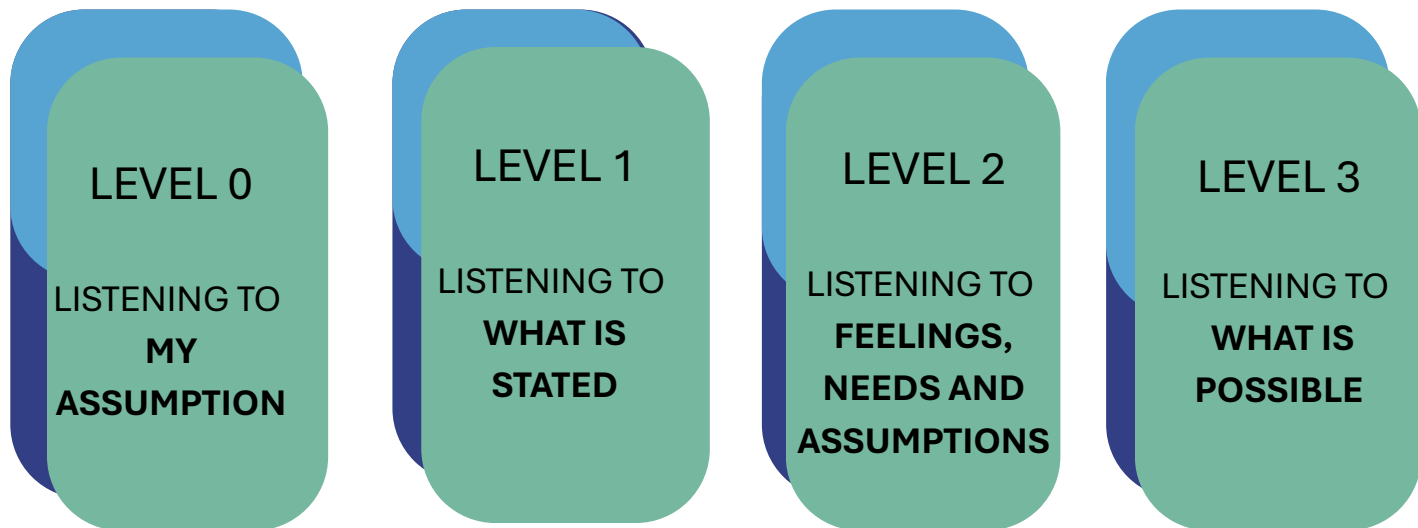
STAKEHOLDER MAP

MY MAP:



NOTES

THREE LEVELS OF LISTENING



THREE LEVELS OF LISTENING

LEVEL 0. Listening to my assumptions:

- Listening to only your assumptions can lead to having a bias for your team members and peers.
- Notice your own inner voice—your judgments, biases, and assumptions.
- Acknowledging one's needs and reactions can help create space to truly listen to the other person without interference.

LEVEL 1. Listening to what is stated:

- Hear the words being spoken — the facts, events and story that is presented.
- Notice the tone and pace.
- Notice if certain words are being repeated or emphasized.

LEVEL 2. Listening to feelings, needs and assumptions:

- Tune into what is unspoken — emotions, needs and underlying beliefs.
- What might they be feeling but not saying? What values or fears are showing up?
- What are some core beliefs that influence the coachee's thinking?

LEVEL 3. Listening to what is possible:

- Shift toward what is emerging — what could be different, which strengths are present and where growth is possible.
- Challenge gently, invite reflection and open doors to new ways of thinking and acting.
- Imagine a possible stretch for your team or peer and reflect on how to accomplish the same.

LEVEL 0: LISTENING TO MY ASSUMPTIONS

This level is about what is happening **inside the team member/peer** — their own narrative, emotions, self-talk.

Anchor question examples:

- How am I feeling when I listen to my team member/peer?
- Is there a bias or judgment I am creating about my team member/peer in this moment?
- To what degree am I fully present right now?

LEVEL 1: LISTENING TO WHAT IS STATED

At this level, you focus on **what is being said**, the **present needs, facts, goals and values**.

Anchor question examples:

- What do you need right now? What is missing for you?
- What would you value most in this situation?
- What support do you feel you need right now?
- What are you asking for — from yourself, or others?

LEVEL 2: LISTENING TO FEELINGS, NEEDS & ASSUMPTIONS

Here, you are tuning in to **tone, body language, energy shifts**, and **what remains unsaid**.

Anchor question examples:

- I noticed a pause when you mentioned that — what came up for you?
- What might you not be saying out aloud yet?
- What are the fears that are holding you back?
- Can you describe in an image or a symbol of what you are feeling right now?

LEVEL 3: LISTEN TO WHAT IS POSSIBLE

This is about **expanding the field of what is possible**, hence co-creating new insights and future.

Anchor question examples:

- What new possibilities are opening up as you share with me?
- If you were to act with the best solution in mind, what would you do differently?
- What might become possible if this challenge was a once in life-time opportunity?
- What is the boldest step you can imagine taking from here?

NOTES

NON-LINEAR THINKING

Following “A” behaviours allow you to practice Non-linearity:

1. ASK: Ask with curiosity. Learn everything that is to learn. Overcome Information asymmetry. How often and where do you this? What are the benefits?
Where do you need to start doing this more?

2. ANTICIPATE: Build a radar system (internal: intuitive guidance and external: network) that allows you to anticipate disruptions, opportunities and discontinuities.

- Are there instances when you listen to your gut feel and it helped you prepare and anticipate well?
- Who are great ‘information – confidantes’ for you who will help you anticipate accurately and provide you advantage?

3. AMPLIFY: Focus on the vision and purpose. Throw light and attention on what will get you ahead v/s focusing on what does not seem to work or fixing things that have incremental on minimal benefits. Manage risks with a forward – momentum appetite.

- What do you usually focus on, what will create growth or what goes missing from a perfect outcome? What is the implication?
- Who are great information – confidantes for you who will help you anticipate accurately and provide you advantage?

4. ALIGN: Excelling at Non-linearity means knowing your tribe of non-linear pioneers and collaborating with them to create exceptional environment for success to happen. This will require investing time, attention and having alignment conversations with relevant stakeholders so that they are prepared, excited and committed to partner with you – all of this done ahead of time. This allows for seamless action when the moment is right.

- Who do you need to ensure you move ahead in the best possible way? What is your trust equation with them?
- Who do you need to include and energize into your circle of influence and impact?

NOTES

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